The Notebook

By Wendy Kesselman

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NOTE: This cutting has been prepared with the vision of 2 females performing the selection. Actor 1 plays the role of Jennie; Actor 2 plays the role of Miss Thorne and Warren (who in the original script is a male; but there is little gender specific notations/pronouns in the text).

(Light comes up on Warren Stone, thirteen, sitting on the edge of the stage, busy writing in a small red notebook. The light suddenly exposing him, he looks up anxiously, then leans forward, speaks to us confidentially.)

WARREN: I have a secret. A terrible secret no one knows. *(In a hushed whisper.)* I like to read. *(Quiet.)* *War and Peace.* My favorite! And in it I found the one person I'd waited for my whole life, the person I'd die for, my favorite, my only heroine - Natasha! *(A pause.)* But I can't go into that now. Because now there's another story, and it's all in here - *(Opening the small red notebook.)* in my notebook. *(He leans even closer to us.)* You see . . . there's this teacher, this terrible teacher. *(pause.)* Miss Thorne.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Maya Angelou once said . . . This is the value of the teacher, who looks at a face and says there's something behind that and I want to reach that person . . .*
ACTOR 2: *I want to influence that person, I want to call out that person who is behind that color, behind that language, behind that culture.*
ACTOR 1: *I believe you can do it....*
ACTOR 2: *But the flip side of this empowerment is also true. A teacher can crush the hopes and dreams of a student just as easily. . .*
ACTOR 1: *with a word, a tone, a look or an indifference that can extinguish the light behind a student's eyes, crush a burgeoning spirit and forever impact the joy of learning and growing.*
ACTOR 2: *The Notebook by Wendy Kesselman captures the extreme vulnerability of students who are ever-sensitive to the judgement of their mentors*

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TOGETHER: *The Notebook by Wendy Kesselman*

(Pacing out, Miss Thorne speaks a poem to a group of unseen girls.)

MISS THORNE: *(With an English accent.)*

I think continually of those who were truly great.
Whose lovely ambition
Was that their lips, still touched with fire,
Should tell of the Spirit, clothed from head to foot in song.

I hope that perhaps one day I too will "think continually of those who were truly great" – *(pause.)* Of all of you perhaps, *(Another pause.)* or at least of some of you - *(soft laugh.)* Well, let's be realistic and hope that maybe one of you, just one, with talent, hard work, luck and determination, will remember . .

WARREN: Well, anyway, that's what she's like - *(Leaning closer.)* This fall, suddenly, she took a liking to me. Me! Of all people. Anyway, one day in September - *(Checking his notebook.)* September twenty-third, to be precise - Miss Thorne [summomed] me.

(Light dims on warren and comes up swiftly on an enchantingly romantic adolescent girl with long hair and haunting, expressive eyes. Jennie, reciting Keats' "La Belle Dame Sam Merci" with a slight Russian accent.)

JENNIE:

O what can ail thee, Knight at arms,
Alone and palely loitering?
The sedge has withered from the lake,
And no birds sing.
I met a Lady in the meads,
Full beautiful, a faery's child,
Her hair was long, her foot was light,
And her eyes were wild -
She found me roots of relish sweet,
And honey wild, and manna dew,
And sure in language strange she said,
"I love thee true."

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WARREN: I couldn't move, couldn't breathe. I recognized her, knew her right away ... Natasha! Just the way I always imagined her, the way she is in my favorite, my absolute favorite -- *War and Peace* ... *(Light comes up on Miss Thorne, gazing at Jennie.)*

MISS THORNE: Well! Is it possible? Right here in our own classroom, someone who makes poetry alive for us, who makes words *live.* With passion. Such passion! *(Looking out at the class.)* Spoken by a girl who had to come from so far away to make us feel at home with our own language again. All the way from Russia, isn't it, Jennie? *(Jennie nods, looks down, then up again quickly at warren, with a shy, joyous smile.)*

WARREN: Jennie. *Jennie!* Oh my God. My God! Okay, okay, so her name wasn't Natasha. So what? She was my heroine, *my* Natasha. *(A pause - His face aglow.)* A reader. Another reader! For how could she have read that poem with such emotion, such feeling, if she weren't a reader herself? *(He pauses.)*

MISS THORNE: A rare child. A rare bird. A bird about to fly. In all my years of teaching I've never ... (*pause.)* Who knows where it will lead? *(Light dims on Miss Thorne and comes up on Jennie in a worn handmade coat, shivering with the cold.)*

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JENNIE: I'm not ashamed! I just thought it would be easier if you picked me up a little bit further away from the school. Easier for you I mean. *(Pause - Slowly)* Every day from now on. *(Pause.)* What do you mean - you'd never live to see this happen? *(Pause.)* Shame has nothing to do with it! *(She hesitates.)* But of course, if you don't want to - *(A pause.)* You will? Really? Really, Papa? *(Quiet.)* That's great. *(Her voice choked)* Thank you. *(Quickly changing the subject.)* Oh guess what we had in Assembly again today ... Impromptu Speaking! It reminds me of those theatre improvisations we used to do with Mama back home. Miss

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Thorne sits on the stage with a red handbag and this little blue book. Inside the bag are the names of everyone in the school. She always has Warren pick the names out of the bag. Guess whose name [was] picked this time? *(Light comes up on Miss Thorne, the red handbag at her side.)* Mine, Papa! And guess what the word was ...

MISS THORNE: *(Opening the small blue book, her finger pointing to a word.)* "Theorem."

JENNIE: *(Laughing happily.)* All I could think to talk about was that Pythagorean Theorem and how I can never get it right. They all laughed, Papa. Like they accepted me ... for the first time. And Miss Thorne laughed too. So hard, so hard. *(Clutching the small blue book, Miss Thorne rocks back and forth, laughing soundlessly)* It's wonderful to make someone laugh, Papa. The way I used to make you and Mama laugh. Around the kitchen table. *(A pause.)* At home. *(For moments she stares at the back of his head, then turns and looks out the window. A tear glistens on her cheek.)* We used to laugh like that all the time ... at home ... in Russia. We used to ... But that's all gone. Now everything's-

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MISS THORNE: *(Leaning closer.)* Listen. I want to let you in on a secret. *(Lowering her voice.)* Tomorrow, tomorrow we embark on a journey into the unknown. *(Almost breathless)* Most of us, after countless obstacles, have finally - *finally!* - begun to read. But to write! To put our secret thoughts, secret feelings no one in the world knows, down on paper. Who knows what treasures may be revealed when tomorrow, tomorrow at last, we begin to write.

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JENNIE: *(Light coming up on her face, as she says her composition from memory aloud.)* Home. Russia! Home! The winding rivers, the vast lakes, the birch trees unfolding forever like the pages in my book of fairy tales. Home! Where my

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father, a physicist, a mathematician, made up theories all day and all night. Home! Where my mother made the most magical costumes in the world, and where we'd arrive at her theatre opening night dressed more outrageously than the actors themselves! Oh, the laughter, the excitement, the kisses, the hugs ... *(A pause.)* But one day my mother came home early - there was no theatre anymore. My father locked his books in a cabinet - the Mathematical Institute had shut its doors. My mother stopped making costumes and started fixing hems. She became a seamstress. My father stopped making up theories and started selling newspapers out on the street. And we came here, to this country ... to our new home. *(Light comes up on Miss Thorne, listening intently.)* Have you ever noticed, on a weeknight, how all the office windows in midtown are lit up at one o'clock in the morning? That's when the women are cleaning, cleaning the buildings after they close. That's where my mother washes her floors every night. My father picks her up in the cab he drives. I speak English to them all the time. They understand it, but they won't speak a single word. They're totally cut off, can't understand Americans at all.

I'm their only child. I've got to do well for them, make them feel I belong, so maybe someday they will too. *(Light comes up more folly on her as she steps even closer to us, right up to the edge of the stage.)* Listen. Shall I tell you something? Yesterday my father drove his cab past the school. I was walking with Heather and Janet and Jane and pretended I didn't see him, didn't even *know* him. My father! A great mathematician, a member of the Academy of Sciences ... now driving a taxi sixteen hours a day, taking orders from drunken men, while his only daughter walks the other way. *(A pause.)* Will I ever stop feeling embarrassed, ashamed? Will I ever really ... *really* belong? Will I ever be able to say that this ... this America ... has become my "safe dwelling"? Will I ever

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be able to call it my home? *(Her face aglow, Miss Thorne comes toward Jennie.)*

MISS THORNE: Well, Jennie. I ... I'm absolutely - *(Looking out, suddenly aware of her class, she continues briskly.)* You need to polish up your grammar of course, work on your sentence structure, enlarge your vocabulary, but, I think I can venture to say that yes ... yes ... it certainly is a start.

WARREN: A start! Was she kidding? It was *perfect!* The best essay I'd heard in my entire life.

JENNIE: *(To Warren - Breaks into a vivid smile.)* Tomorrow, when we read out *own* poem, the one we made up ourselves –

WARREN: *(Turning to us.)* She was so excited, so worked up I got worried. *(a step forward}* You made one up *already?*

JENNIE: Right after she gave me the assignment. But I'd been thinking about it ... for long time. *(Ecstatic, Jennie spins and spins)*

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(Light reveals Jennie, standing utterly still. Hurriedly Warren rushes across the stage, stops. Her back to him, in the grey light, she almost seems trapped inside the Sheffield walls.)

WARREN: What happened? Did you read it? *(Jennie remains still unmoving.}* Did you? *(Silence. Hesitant, Warren takes a step toward her.)* Jennie?

JENNIE: *(A muffled voice.)* I read it. Yes.

WARREN: And? Did she like it? *(Still silence.)* Did she? *(Jennie turns to him, her face bathed in tears.)*

JENNIE: *(Almost inaudible.)* Nyet. Nyet! *(Desperate.)* I can't go back there. I can't face her.

WARREN: Of course you can face her. Who is she that you can't face her?

JENNIE: She's ... You know who she is.

WARREN. But it's not as if she's *God* or anything. *(Silence.)* I mean she's not *that* great.

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JENNIE: She is, Warren. You know she is. *(A pause.)* Without her ... without her I would never ... *(In a rush.)* never have understood anything! Keats, Dickinson! They know, they understand everything I've ever gone through. Like she does. Because, in *her* class, it's not just learning to read, to write - it's to feel, truly feel ...

WARREN: *(Interrupting.)* But you didn't write that in your poem, did you? About her, I mean. About your secret feelings. You didn't read that in front of the entire class? *(pause.)* Did you? *(Jennie is still.)* Well ... I mean even if you did, you've got to go back. You'll flunk school otherwise.

JENNIE: *(Breaking in.)* I don't care! Without her there is no school anyway.

WARREN: *(To audience)* I didn't know what to say. I'd never seen her like that. She was so worried, so upset. And I didn't ... I just didn't . .. I mean ... I don't know how to help her. *(Light comes up on Jennie, standing in shadow in Miss Thorne's classroom. Miss Thorne comes in, switches on the light. Seeing Jennie, she stops.)*

MISS THORNE: Here so early? Classes don't begin till eight. *(Silence. Slowly, almost as if she were walking on eggshells, Jennie moves toward her.)*

JENNIE: I ... I wanted to talk to you. *(Still silence.)* That is I - *(Almost inaudible.)* I . . . *(She stops.)*

MISS THORNE: Yes? What is it?

JENNIE: I've been so worried. So afraid I did something wrong. Ruined something.

MISS THORNE: I don't know what you -

JENNIE: *(In a rush, overlapping on "you:")* Tell me. Please. What I've said. Done. Because ... you ... you're not -

MISS THORNE: *(Interrupting)* Nonsense. You've ruined nothing. Done nothing wrong. *(Jennie's face lights up. She takes a step closer. Miss Thorne ,picks up a blue exam book.}* [But] I feel it is my duty to warn you. Your last exam is, I'm afraid ... unacceptable. For that matter, all your recent work - Essays, fiction, even

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your poetry, Jennie! - *(She looks away.)* Yes ... even that ... has not been up to your usual standard. *(Looking back at Jennie.)* It's become, *you've* become ... undisciplined. *(She stops. Jennie is still.)* You've let the, shall we say ... passion ... overtake you. Creativity requires discipline, Jennie. Without that, it becomes self-indulgent. *(Jennie looks down . A pause.)*

JENNIE: *(To audience . . . Wildly.)* What's happening? I don't understand what's happening. I keep thinking - praying! - it's all some horrible nightmare and I'm going to wake up and the whole thing will have gone away. Because if I don't, I mean, if I don't wake up there really is no life for me anymore. *(The light dims on her.)*

WARREN: *(To us.)* And as the weeks went by, I saw her less and less - And when I *did* see her, the look on her face, in her eyes, scared me. *(Jennie stares straight ahead - a haunted gaze -)* Her face was frightened - as if she were drowning. *(refers to his notebook)* This was May. May sixteenth. One of the last days of school. A day that passed quickly, till there was only one thing left -- Friday afternoon assembly. The whole school rocked with laughter, as person after person came up and improvised ridiculous stories. *{Warren undoes the clasp of the red handbag, reaches in, pulls out a piece of paper)* Jennie Litvinov! *(The sound reverberates through the audience. Then, stillness.)* I kept praying. Please. Don't let her be here.

(And then, from the back of the theatre itself, Jennie appears, slowly makes her way through the audience to the stage, climbs the steps. Pale, thin, as if all life had been drained out of her, she turns to us, her face dead white.)

MISS THORNE: *(A tense smile.)* Ahh. For a moment I thought you weren't going to honor us with an appearance .. *(Jennie seems to cringe beneath her words.)* But here you are! So. *(Miss Thorne opens the little blue book, closes her eyes, puts her finger down on the page. Opening her eyes, delighted.)* "Crumpets!" *(Silence.)* Well? *(Not*

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a word comes from Jennie's mouth.) I'm waiting. We're all waiting. *(Slowly Jennie opens her mouth.)*

JENNIE: In India there is a custom ...

MISS THORNE: *(Laughing.)* India? What does India have to do with it?

JENNIE: *(Going on.)* An ancient custom when a servant has been hurt, mistreated by his master in some way, instead of getting angry or taking revenge, he sits outside the master's house, not eating anything -

MISS THORNE: *(Breaking in. Airily, gaily.)* Miss ... Litvinov! I cannot see what this ... story, this "custom," as you call it, has to do with ... You are not making us laugh, Miss Litvinov. This is not amusing.

(Not seeming to hear, Jennie steps closer to us, right up to the edge of the stage. And Miss Thorne stops speaking, mesmerized despite herself, as is the whole assembly, by Jennie's story, her strangely white face.)

JENNIE: He's waiting, you see, waiting for the master to say something - anything! - not an apology, just a word, one word ... one kind word. And he waits there, all curled up ... *(Slowly sitting down on a step.)* curled up outside his master's house until ... if necessary ... he starves himself to death. *(A silence in the room.)*

MISS THORNE: *(Weary.)* That story has nothing to do with anything. Why all this drama? Hasn't everyone at Sheffield been kind to you? Extremely kind, in fact. *(Sofi.)* Why do to me? Especially to me. *(The whole assembly is absolutely still as Jennie remains motionless.)* Frankly I'm at a loss to help [you]. I simply don't know how to help [you] anymore.

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WARREN: I tried to find her. I went all the way out there. On the subway. Alone. *(A pause.)* Her parents don't live there anymore. Vanished. Like in a fairy tale. *(Another pause.)* Everyone says I have to forget about her. But I'll never forget. Never! *(Almost a whisper.)* I *can't*. She's ... *(He stops.)* my fairy tale. *(A*

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pause.) Jennie loved her. She loved Miss Thorne. I didn't think anybody ... Nobody loves Miss Thorne! But Jennie did.

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